I also made goodwill visits to Israel, Nigeria, Egypt, Chile, Brazil, Indonesia and Australia, which were helpful in building stronger military-to-military ties and for projecting the image of the Indian armed forces as a professional organization.

Our 'Look East Policy' has given a renewed focus on our relations with countries in East Asia and Japan. The visit by the Japanese prime minister at the end of 2009 provided impetus to India's comprehensive engagement with Japan, and imparted more depth to our strategic and global partnership. India's increasing engagement with multilateral global and regional groupings like BRIC (Brazil, Russia, India and China), SCO (Shangai Cooperation Organization), ASEAN (Association for South East Asian Nations), BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation), SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) and so on, is in keeping with the growing stature of our country. These multilateral relationships, though primarily designed to enhance cooperation in trade, commerce, social and cultural dimensions, are going to have security connotations as well. The creation of an environment of peace and stability would be a precondition for progress and prosperity in any region. Therefore, it is in our national interest that we take the lead in our region, and at times even offer asymmetric and non-reciprocal commitments to other smaller countries in the regional groupings to help them overcome their domestic problems.

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[1] Ministry of External Affairs, Annual Report 2009–10.

[2] *Hindustan Times*, 17 October 2005.

[3] White Paper issued by the Government of India, No. III, p. 85.

[4] Lord Curzon, 'Frontiers', Romanes Lecture of 1907.

[5] *India Today*, 22 December 2008, p. 34.

[6] Valerie Palme Wilson, *Newsweek*, 9 August 2010, pp. 26–27.

[7] Ministry of External Affairs, Annual Report 2009–10, p. i.